



NONPARTISAN VOTER INFORMATION APP

UDecide

Complete Feature Specification

User Guide & Feature Reference • May 2026

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Introduction & Getting Started

UDecide is a free, nonpartisan mobile app that puts all the political and civic information you need in one place. Whether you want to find your representatives, track upcoming elections, follow legislation, or fact-check a political claim, UDecide gives you reliable, unbiased information sourced from official government databases.

This document describes every feature in UDecide from a user's point of view — what each screen does, how to use it, and what to expect.

Nonpartisan Promise

UDecide presents information from official sources without ranking, endorsing, or favoring any political party, candidate, or ideology. All perspectives are given equal treatment.

Creating an Account

- 1** **Open the app** — you will land on the Sign In screen with a deep-navy background.
- 2** **Tap "Create Account"** to open the registration form. Enter your first name, last name, email address, and a password (minimum 8 characters, at least one number).
- 3** **Set up your profile** — after registering you are taken to the Profile Setup screen where you enter your U.S. address (street, city, state, ZIP). This address is used to find your local representatives and elections.
- 4** **Tap "Continue"** to arrive at your personalised Dashboard.

Setting Your Location

UDecide uses your address to show you the right representatives, elections, and local legislation. You set this when you register and can update it in your Profile. You can also temporarily switch to any other U.S. address using the **Address Override** feature (see Feature 10) without permanently changing your account address.

Returning Users	Enter your email and password on the Sign In screen. Tap "Forgot Password?" if you need to reset it.	Password Reset	Enter your registered email address and follow the on-screen instructions to create a new password.
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FEATURE 01

Dashboard

Your personalised civic home screen

The Dashboard is the first screen you see after signing in. It greets you by name and shows your current city and state so you know the app is tuned to your location. Below the greeting is a scrollable grid of cards — one for each major feature.

What You'll See

- **Welcome header** — your first name and location chip (e.g., "Austin, TX") displayed prominently at the top.
- **Quick-access cards** — large, tappable tiles for each feature: Representatives, Elections, Legislation, Voter Tools, Political Parties, Political System Guide, Polls, and Fact Checker.
- **Each card shows** an icon, a title, and a short description of that feature.

How to Use It

- 1 Scroll down to browse all available features.
- 2 Tap any card to go directly to that feature.
- 3 Use the tab bar at the bottom to jump between the five main sections at any time.

Tip

The Dashboard is always accessible by tapping the home tab (house icon) at the bottom of the screen.

FEATURE 02

Representatives

Find every official who represents you — from Congress to city hall

The Representatives screen shows every elected official who serves your address, organised by level of government. You can expand any card to see detailed information and contact details.

Government Levels

Federal	Your two U.S. Senators and one U.S. House Representative for your congressional district.	State	Your state governor, state senator, and state house representative.
County	Your county commissioner or equivalent county-level official.	City	Your mayor and city council member for your district.

What Each Card Shows

- **Name, title, and party** — colour-coded party badge (blue for Democrat, red for Republican, yellow for Independent, etc.).
- **State and district** — the geographic area they represent.
- **Years in office** — how long they have served in their current role.
- **Voting record summary** — a short description of their recent legislative activity.
- **Contact information** — office phone number and official website (tap to open in your browser).

Using the Representatives Screen

- 1 Scroll through the list — representatives are grouped by level (Federal, State, County, City) with a coloured header for each group.
- 2 Tap a card to expand it and reveal full contact details and voting record.
- 3 Tap the phone number or website link inside an expanded card to contact your representative.

Data Source

Representative data is sourced from official government records and updated regularly. When an internet connection is unavailable, the app shows the most recently cached data.

FEATURE 03

Elections & Ballots

Never miss an election — dates, candidates, and deadlines in one place

The Elections screen lists every upcoming election relevant to your address: presidential, congressional, state, and local. Each election card shows the full timeline of important dates and lets you explore the candidates running for each office.

What Each Election Card Shows

- **Election name and type** — e.g., "General Election", "Primary Election", "Local Runoff".
- **Election date** — prominently displayed with a countdown or a "Today" indicator.
- **Registration deadline** — the last day to register to vote for this election.
- **Early voting window** — the start and end dates for in-person early voting.
- **Absentee / mail-in ballot deadline** — the last day to request or return an absentee ballot.
- **Ballot status tags** — colour-coded labels such as "Upcoming", "Early Voting Open", "Registration Open", or "Closed".

Viewing Candidates

- 1 Tap an election card to expand it and see a list of contested offices (e.g., U.S. Senate, Governor, State House District 42).
- 2 Tap an office name to see all candidates running for that position.
- 3 Each candidate card shows their name, party, and a brief background note.

Important

UDecide does not endorse any candidate. Candidates are listed in alphabetical order with equal prominence regardless of party affiliation.

Staying on Top of Deadlines

All key dates are shown for every election. If a deadline is approaching within seven days, it is highlighted in amber so it catches your eye. Check back regularly as dates can be updated by election authorities.

FEATURE 04

Legislation Tracker

Follow bills in Congress and your state legislature

The Legislation Tracker lets you browse and search bills at both the federal and state level. Each bill entry shows its current status, a plain-English summary, and its journey through the legislative process.

Browsing Bills

- **Filter tabs** — switch between "Federal" and "State" to focus on the level of government you care about.
- **Bill card** — shows the bill number (e.g., HB 1234), a short title, the current status badge, and the date of the most recent action.
- **Status badges** — colour-coded indicators: Introduced (grey), In Committee (blue), Passed Chamber (amber), Enrolled (green), Signed into Law (dark green), Vetoed (red), Failed (light red).

Bill Detail View

Tap any bill card to open the full detail view:

- **Plain-English summary** — a concise explanation of what the bill does.
- **Sponsor and co-sponsors** — the legislator(s) who introduced the bill.
- **Chamber of origin** — whether the bill started in the House or Senate.
- **Legislative timeline** — a chronological list of every action taken on the bill (introduced, committee assignment, votes, presidential action).
- **Vote record** — the most recent roll call vote showing the Yea/Nay breakdown.
- **Full text link** — a link to the official bill text on congress.gov or your state legislature's website.

Data Sources

Federal bills are sourced from Congress.gov. State bills are sourced from LegiScan, which covers all 50 state legislatures. Both services require an internet connection; cached data is shown when offline.

Searching Legislation

- 1 Tap the search icon (magnifying glass) at the top of the Legislation screen.
- 2 Type a keyword, bill number, or topic (e.g., "healthcare", "HB 452", "tax").
- 3 Results update in real time as you type. Tap a result to open the bill detail.

FEATURE 05

Voter Status Tools

Everything you need to know before you vote

The Voter Status Tools screen consolidates practical voting information for your specific state and address. Each card is a self-contained reference for a different aspect of the voting process.

Registration Information

Shows your state's voter registration rules: the deadline to register before the next election, whether your state offers same-day registration, and a direct link to your state's official registration portal.

Polling Place Finder

Displays the name and address of your assigned polling location based on your registered address. Includes polling place hours for Election Day and a map link so you can get directions.

Early Voting

Shows whether your state offers early in-person voting, the dates of the early voting period, and the locations of nearby early voting sites.

Absentee & Mail-In Voting

Explains your state's rules for voting by mail: whether you need an excuse, the request deadline, the return deadline, and whether ballot drop boxes are available.

Voter ID Requirements

Lists the specific ID documents your state accepts at the polls. Some states accept a wide range of documents; others have strict photo ID requirements. This card explains exactly what you need to bring.

State-Specific

All information on this screen is tailored to your state's specific laws, which vary widely across the country. Always verify critical dates with your local election authority.

FEATURE 06

Political Parties

Understand the major and minor parties — without the spin

The Political Parties screen provides neutral, factual profiles of the main U.S. political parties. Parties are listed alphabetically with no implied ranking or preference.

Parties Covered

Democratic Party	Founded 1828 · Center-left	Republican Party	Founded 1854 · Center-right
Libertarian Party	Founded 1971 · Classical liberal	Green Party	Founded 1984 · Progressive / eco
Independent	No party affiliation — runs on individual platforms	Constitution Party	Founded 1992 · Paleoconservative

What Each Party Profile Contains

- **Short history** — founding year and brief origin story.
- **Core values** — the principles the party states in its platform documents.
- **Key policy positions** — factual summaries of the party's stated stances on major issues (economy, healthcare, environment, foreign policy, social issues) drawn directly from official party platforms.
- **Current leadership** — national chair and prominent elected officials.
- **Electoral performance** — recent election results and seats currently held.
- **Official website link** — tap to visit the party's official site for more information.

Editorial Policy

Platform summaries are paraphrased directly from each party's own official platform documents. UDecide does not add commentary, characterisations, or comparisons between parties.

Political System Guide

Civic education for every American — easy to understand, easy to share

The Political System Guide is an interactive civics reference that explains how the U.S. government works. It is written for everyone, from first-time voters to those who want a refresher.

Topics Covered

The Three Branches of Government

Explains the roles of the Legislative (Congress), Executive (President), and Judicial (Supreme Court and federal courts) branches, and how they are structured.

Checks and Balances

Describes how each branch limits the power of the others — for example, how Congress can override a presidential veto, and how the courts can strike down laws as unconstitutional.

How a Bill Becomes a Law

Step-by-step walkthrough: introduction in either chamber, committee review, floor debate, vote, conference committee (if needed), presidential action, and potential veto override.

The U.S. Constitution

Summary of the Constitution's structure — the Preamble, the seven original Articles, and the 27 Amendments — with plain-language explanations.

The Bill of Rights

Plain-English explanation of the first ten Amendments: freedom of speech, right to bear arms, protection from unreasonable searches, right to a fair trial, and more.

The Electoral College

Explains what the Electoral College is, how electors are allocated per state, how the popular vote and electoral vote interact, and what happens if no candidate reaches 270 electoral votes.



Voting Rights History

Timeline of major milestones: the 15th Amendment (1870), 19th Amendment (1920), Voting Rights Act (1965), 26th Amendment (1971), and ongoing developments.

Each topic is presented as an expandable card. Tap a card header to reveal the full content. Tap again to collapse it.

FEATURE 08

Political Polls

Have your say on civic topics — see how the community feels

The Polls screen hosts a rotating set of community polls on civic and political topics. All polls are nonpartisan and focus on policy issues, not partisan preferences.

How Polls Work

- 1 Browse the list of active polls. Each card shows the poll question, the number of votes cast, and — if you've already voted — a live results bar.
- 2 Tap a poll card to open it. Read the question and any context provided.
- 3 Tap your chosen answer. The results reveal immediately, showing the percentage breakdown across all options.
- 4 Your vote is saved — you cannot vote on the same poll twice.

Filtering Polls

Use the topic filter chips at the top of the screen to narrow polls by subject: **All, Economy, Healthcare, Environment, Foreign Policy, Education, Infrastructure.**

Results Display

- Animated horizontal bars show the percentage for each answer option.
- The total vote count appears below the question.
- Your chosen answer is highlighted with a checkmark.
- Results update in real time as other users vote.

About These Polls

Polls are not scientific surveys. They reflect the opinions of UDecide users who choose to participate and are not representative of the general population.

FEATURE 09

AI Fact Checker

Ask any political question — get a nonpartisan, sourced answer

The Fact Checker is a conversational AI assistant powered by Google Gemini. It is designed to answer political and civic questions, check factual claims, and explain complex policy topics in plain language — all without political bias.

What You Can Ask

Fact Checking	"Did Congress pass a budget last year?" or "Is it true that the minimum wage hasn't changed since 2009?"	Bill Summaries	"What does the Inflation Reduction Act actually do?" or "Summarise H.R. 1234 in plain English."
Civics Questions	"How does the filibuster work?" or "What is the difference between a resolution and a bill?"	Policy Context	"What are the main arguments for and against universal basic income?" (presented neutrally with all sides)

Using the Fact Checker

- 1 Tap the text input at the bottom of the screen and type your question.
- 2 Tap the send button. The AI begins responding immediately — text streams in word-by-word so you don't have to wait.
- 3 Read the response. You can ask follow-up questions to dig deeper into any topic.
- 4 Tap the new conversation button (top right) to clear the chat and start fresh.

Suggested Questions

If you're not sure what to ask, the screen shows a set of suggested starter questions. Tap any of them to send it instantly.

AI Limitations

The AI may occasionally make mistakes or have a knowledge cutoff date for recent events. Always verify important facts with primary sources such as congress.gov or your local election authority. The AI will always present multiple perspectives on contested policy questions and will never express a partisan opinion.

FEATURE 10

Address Override

Explore political data for any U.S. address — without changing your account

Address Override lets you temporarily view the app as if you lived somewhere else. This is useful if you are researching elections in another district, helping a family member, or simply curious about how the political landscape differs in another city or state.

How to Use It

- 1 Go to the **More** tab, then tap **"Address Override"**.
- 2 Enter any U.S. address in the form fields: street address, city, state, and ZIP code.
- 3 Tap **"Apply Override"**. The entire app immediately switches to show data for that location.
- 4 A gold banner appears at the top of every screen to remind you that you are viewing an overridden address, not your registered location.
- 5 To return to your normal address, tap **"Clear Override"** in the banner or revisit the Address Override screen and tap the clear button.

What Changes When Override Is Active

- **Representatives** — shows officials for the overridden address's district.
- **Elections** — shows elections relevant to the overridden state and district.
- **Legislation** — shows state legislation for the overridden state.
- **Voter Tools** — shows voting rules and deadlines for the overridden state.

Your Account is Safe

Address Override is temporary. It does not change your account's registered address. Your personal address is preserved and restored the moment you clear the override.

FEATURE 11

Profile & Settings

Manage your account and personal information

The Profile screen lets you view and update your account information. Access it by tapping the **More** tab and then **"My Profile"**, or by tapping your name at the top of the Dashboard.

What You Can Do

Edit Your Name

Update your first and last name. Your name appears in the Dashboard greeting and is used to personalise the app experience.

Update Your Address

Change your registered address at any time. When you save a new address, all location-dependent features automatically refresh to reflect the new location.

Account Information

View your registered email address. Your email address cannot be changed after registration — it serves as your permanent login identifier.

Sign Out

Sign out of your account. Your data is preserved on the device — signing back in with the same credentials restores everything. Signing out on a shared device is recommended to protect your privacy.

The "More" Tab

The More tab (last tab in the navigation bar) also provides quick links to features that don't have their own tab:

■ **Voter Tools** — jump directly to the Voter Status Tools screen.

■ **Political Parties** — open the party profiles screen.

■ **Political Guide** — open the civics education guide.

■ **Polls** — go to the community polls.

■ **Fact Checker** — open the AI chatbot.

■ **Address Override** — open the location switcher.

■ **My Profile** — open the profile/settings screen.

Navigation & App Design

How to get around UDecide

Tab Bar Navigation

The bottom tab bar is always visible and provides instant access to the five main sections of UDecide:

Home (House icon)	Returns you to the Dashboard from anywhere in the app.	Representatives (People icon)	Your elected officials at all levels of government.
Elections (Calendar icon)	Upcoming elections, key dates, and candidates.	Legislation (Document icon)	Track federal and state bills.
More (Grid icon)	Voter tools, parties, guide, polls, fact checker, and profile.		

Design & Accessibility

- **Dark navy theme** — easy on the eyes in both bright and low-light environments.
- **Large touch targets** — all buttons and cards are sized for easy tapping on any phone screen size.
- **High contrast** — white text on navy and dark text on light cards both exceed WCAG AA contrast ratios.
- **Haptic feedback** — tapping important actions produces a subtle vibration to confirm your input.
- **Offline support** — the app caches data locally so you can browse representatives, legislation, and guides even without an internet connection.

Privacy

- All account data is stored securely on your device using encrypted local storage. No personal data is sent to external servers beyond the API requests needed to load content.
- The app does not track your usage, sell your data, or show you targeted advertisements.
- API requests to government data sources are anonymised — your personal address is never included in these requests.

